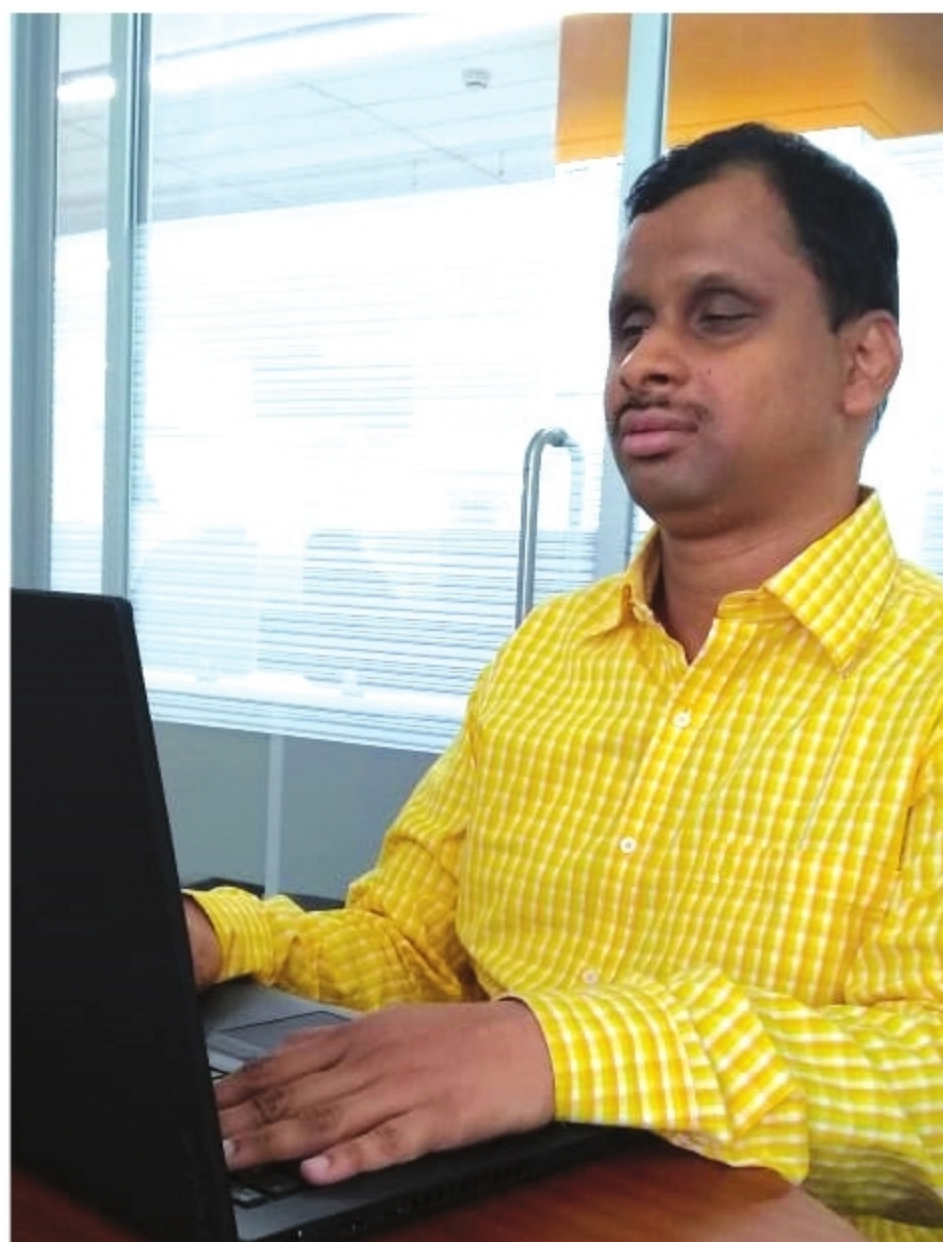


“It is absolutely fine to convert an open source product into a business as long as the ‘free as in freedom’ values are not compromised and the code always remains open”



Open source advocate and India's first completely blind IT professional, **Krishnakant (KK) Mane**, is on a mission to replace costly proprietary programs with open source alternatives. Through his NGO, Digital Freedom Foundation, he is also aiming to make the use of free software more widespread in the education domain.

GNUKhata, an open source invoicing, inventory management and accounting automation software, is one of the projects being developed at the Digital Freedom Foundation. Mane initiated the project in 2009 with the help of a small team of programmers. The aim was to ease the operations of technically underserved sections of the Indian economy, especially small businesses, startups and traders, who couldn't afford expensive enterprise programs. Mane now wants to commercialise the product by launching an integrated enterprise version of the software.

In an exclusive chat with **Longjam Dineshwori** of **EFY Networks**, Mane shares the idea behind launching an enterprise version of GNUKhata and refutes the myth that “open source software can't do business.” He also talks about various business models one can choose to earn a profit from open source projects, the benefits of using the General Public License (GPL), and much more. Excerpts from the chat follow:

Q Can you take us through the early journey of the GNUKhata project?

Back in 2007, I used to be a FOSS consultant and also a project fellow at the Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education at TIFR (Tata Institute of Fundamental Research).

In the process of helping several companies and organisations shift from proprietary to open source IT infrastructure, I distinctly noticed that the computers involved in accounting related activities would never switch over to using open source. This was because there was no professional quality open source accounting software that came anywhere close to most popular proprietary accounting software.

So, the need was very obvious. It was just the question of who would address this gap and when. I felt